
LE PIGEON DE PAPIER

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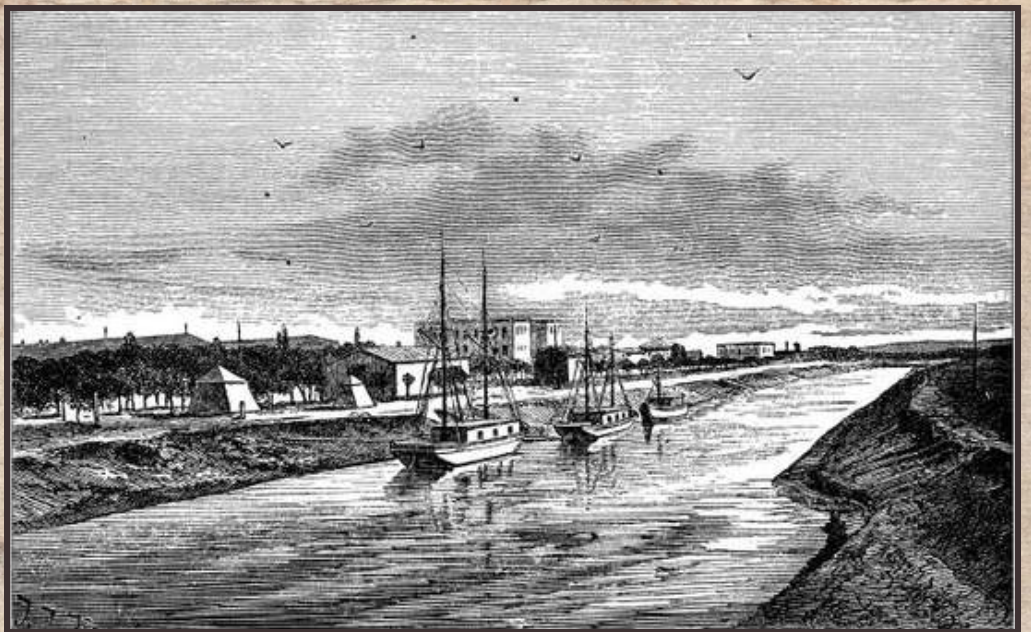
EGYPT'S PAST

This Old Cold War

With the recent fall of the Berlin Wall, it's an important time to look back at these past decades, and remember all that's happened. All that's been won, and all that's been lost.

In this edition of *Le Pigeon de Papier*, we take a look at Egypt, a quintessential microcosm of the East-West struggle. From the critical Suez Canal, to the Aswan Dam, to the Yom-Kippur War, we bring you the information that matters. The stories that can't be forgotten, lest we never make progress. In times like these ignorance is not a lack of opinion, but an intentional choice, and not one we stand for. It is our responsibility to know our conflicts, our enemies, and ourselves.

THE SUEZ CRISIS AND
THE COLD WAR



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The Birth of Israel

Britain has protected and governed Palestine since the fall of the Ottoman Empire. With the close of WWII, postwar financial struggles forced her to vacate the territory. On November 20th, 1947, the UN General Assembly voted to partition Palestine in half, forming Jewish and Arab Palestine



The Arab sphere took issue with this because Palestine's population was 2-1 Arab to Jewish, but Jewish Palestine got half of the land, unproportional to the population split. Furthermore, Jewish Palestine got the most economically viable land.

Jewish Ambitions

Organized under the Haganah and other militias, Jewish forces enacted the "Plan Dalet," consolidating their control over mixed Arab-Jewish areas. This continued power play led to May 14th, 1948, when Israel declared independence from Palestine.

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The First Arab-Israeli War

One day after Israel's declaration of independence, on May 15th, 1948, Five Arab countries- Egypt, Transjordan (to become Jordan), Iraq, Syria, and Lebanon, supported by contingents from Saudi Arabia and Yemen, invaded Israel to oppose the Jewish state. Though they united under the banner of freeing Palestine, each country had their own ambitions.

Transjordan's king Abdullah aspired to annex parts of Palestine, and had previously made secret agreements with Israeli Jewish leaders to aid in achieving this.

Egypt, prime minister Mahmoud al-Nokrashy was firmly against going to war, but King Farouk overruled him in favour of trying to thwart King Abdullah's ambitions.

Iraq and Syria both harbored pan-Arab plans for the post-war Middle East.

A Team, Divided

Though these countries united under one public goal, their conflicting private interests resulted in very poor coordination, communication, and teamwork. This allowed the Israeli forces, who were armed more poorly compared to the Arab forces, to hold their own through their superior organization and communication.

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Operation Yoav

In October of 1948, Israeli forces launched Operation Yoav. Operation Yoav aimed to accomplish a number of things, including connecting Israeli forces, breaking through the Gaza-Beersheba corridor, capturing Beersheba and Ashdod, and delivering the Egyptian military a heavy defeat. After Operation Yoav's success, the Egyptians were forced to relinquish most of the Negev territory while having their incompetence exposed.

Operation Horev

At the end of 1948, the Israeli forces launched another strategic plan, Operation Horev, which lasted until early January 1949. The primary goal was to eliminate the Egyptian military from the Negev Desert and southern Palestine by trapping and destroying Egyptian army units.

Operation Horev also aimed to advance deep into the Sinai Peninsula and eliminate Egyptian military bases along the way while establishing Israeli territorial control over the entire Negev region. This control would give them a claim to the land when international tensions imposed a ceasefire.



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Operation Horev - The Three Phases

Operation Horev happened in three phases.

Phase 1 – The Diversionary Attack (December 22–23)

The Golani Brigade, supported by Israeli Air Force bombing launched a diversionary assault on the Gaza–Rafah Road.

Phase 2 – The Main Assault (December 27)

The 8th Armoured Brigade attacked Egyptian positions at al-Auja through a surprise desert route. After 24 hours of combat, Egyptian forces surrendered and the entire Egyptian eastern front collapsed

Phase 3 – The Invasion of Sinai(December 28–30)

Israeli forces crossed the Egyptian border on December 28th and advanced into Sinai. The Negev Brigade and 8th Armoured Brigade occupied Um-Qatef, captured Abu-Agila, and threatened the Egyptian air base at El-Arish

The Final Assault

On January 3rd, Israeli forces launched a final assault on Rafah, attempting again to trap the entire Egyptian army. After three days of heavy fighting on January 6th, Egypt, facing international pressures, announced its willingness to enter armistice negotiations, effectively ending major hostilities.

This battle allowed Israel to demonstrate military superiority by defeating and routing the Egyptian army, and create strong leverage for the following armistice negotiations. After the armistice was signed on February 24th, Israel controlled the Negev plateau and all of southern Palestine, minus Gaza and a small portion of the southern Negev, while Al-Auja was designated as a demilitarized zone.

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The end of the War

Britain, alarmed by Israel's success, invoked the 1936 Anglo-Egyptian Treaty, threatening direct military intervention. On January 6th & 7th, Israeli aircraft shot down five Royal Air Force Spitfires who were attempting to signal the Israel Defence Force (IDF) to halt operations, killing two British pilots. The USA followed these events by applying her own diplomatic pressures to Israel, calling for an immediate cessation of operations. Finally, Israeli Prime Minister David Ben-Gurion ordered Israeli forces to withdraw from Sinai.

Treaties and Reparations

Following the Egyptian-Israeli armistice in February 1949, a series of armistices were signed between Israel and the other Arab nations:

- March 23rd 1949: Armistice Agreement signed between Israel and Lebanon
- April 3rd 1949 Armistice Agreement signed between Israel and Transjordan
- July 20th 1949 Armistice Agreement signed between Israel and Syria
- Iraq never signed an armistice agreement

By the end of the war, Israel had expanded its control of the original Palestine to about 78%, considerably more than it had before the war. Transjordan also successfully annexed the West Bank, while Palestine politically vanished and the Egyptian monarchy's legitimacy was undermined by their embarrassing string of losses

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The Crisis (1956)

In the Summer of 1956, a kettle that's been steeping for a very long time indeed finally began to boil over. Prompted by continued British control over Egypt and financial possibilities, Egyptian President Gamal Nasser nationalized the Suez Canal near the end of July. This made Britain and France very unhappy, since they owned much of the stocks of the Suez Canal Company prior to this point, and both relied heavily on it for shipping, especially the transportation of oil. France was particularly angry with Egypt since Nasser was funding Algerian resistance forces opposing French colonial influence in north Africa. [The Paper Pigeon has previously covered this topic in detail in "France in Northwest Africa"] Israel had many reasons to resent Egypt. After all, Egypt had specifically blocked them from access to both the Suez Canal and the crucial Straits of Tiran. Given that Nasser had signed the Egyptian-Czechoslovak arms deal that bought war materiel from the Soviet bloc, the whole of the West wanted to do something about Egypt.

To work out a solution, in mid August 1956, The Suez Conference was held in Lancaster House, London, UK. 24 countries were invited, all of which attended except for Greece and Egypt. Out of the remaining 22 countries, 18 voted that the Suez Canal should be reverted back to international ownership,

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The Crisis (1956) (Continued)

such that previous stakeholders could rebuy their shares. However, President Nasser unequivocally denied this proposal. Despite the feeling that Nasser was a problem, US leadership very clearly indicated their view that an attack on Egypt would be a mistake. Besides, Eisenhower feared how taking such drastic action would affect his chances of re-election. However, regardless of what America thought, Britain and France had already made up their minds as for what to do.

Britain, France, and Israel signed the Protocol of Sèvres on October 26th, 1956. This meant that they would each use their own military power to attack Egypt. Their invasion became known as the Tripartite Aggression. Israel struck first, invading Eastern Egypt on the 29th, with Britain and France arriving on November 5th. The Egyptians responding by sabotaging the canal, for instance by sinking ships inside it. Ultimately however, the Egyptian forces were massively outnumbered, and the Tripartite Aggressors took over.

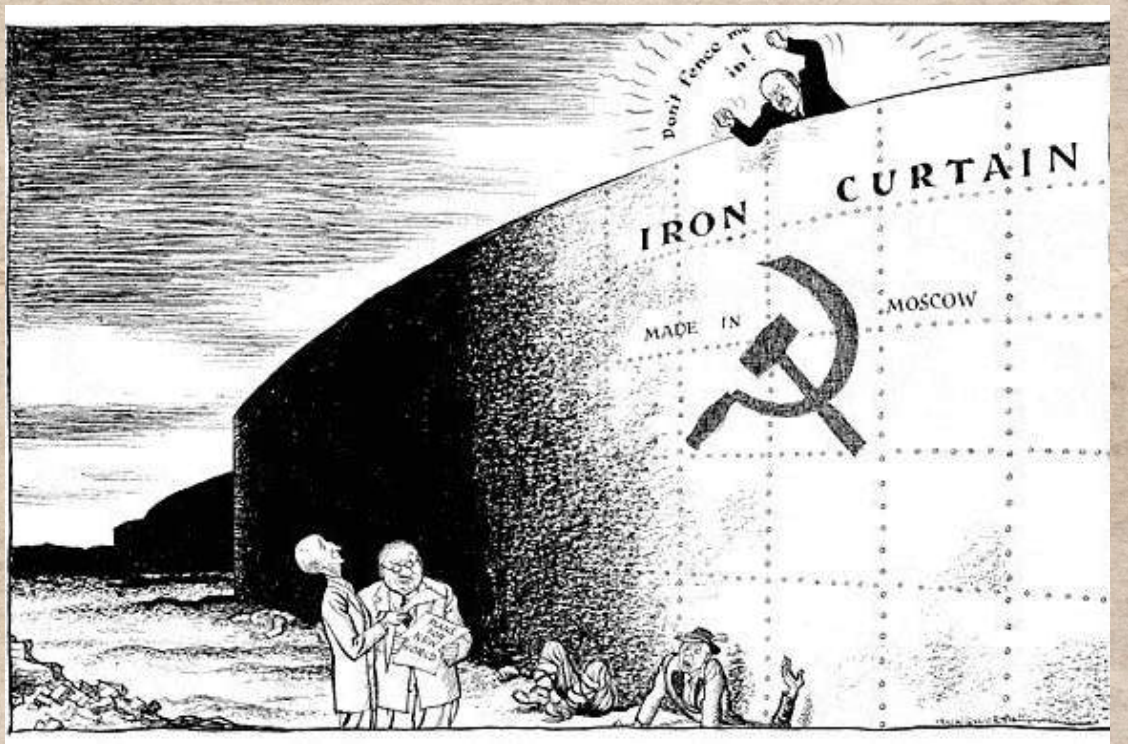
But the biggest powers in the world were not happy with Britain, France, and Israel. The US was very concerned that this use of force would drive Egypt forthwith into the Soviet bloc. Their disapproval was heightened by the fact that they had not been consulted about any of the attacks on Egypt. In the East, the Soviet were also unhappy. Western control in Egypt meant that access to the Suez Canal could be blocked entirely for red nations. In this rare occasion, both the US and USSR wanted the offending forces out of Egypt. Thus, with the threat of sanctions, Britain and France withdrew from Egypt on November 7th after a UN peacemaking force was deployed. Israeli forces followed suit in the coming months. Egypt was reclaimed. For now.

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Playing the Game: The East and West in '56

An argument could be made that the Suez Crisis began as a colonial struggle. Britain felt that they owned one of the most important waterways on the planet and had to come to terms with the fact that Egypt was not a pet they had domesticated, rather a fully independent organism. However, as the conflict progressed, it became increasingly tied to the US-Soviet conflict. Gamal Nasser bought war materiel from the Soviet bloc in the year prior to the crisis, antagonising The West. In return, France, Britain, and Israel had extra incentives to impose further control over Egypt. As a member of the Western Bloc, a country attempting to “remove the soviet” from Egypt would be seen more favourably by the US.



While the “hot” conflict was between Egypt and the Tripartite Aggressors, the US and USSR were focussed on playing the “cold” game. America of course didn’t want Egypt to being dependent on Soviet arms, but Eisenhower’s biggest concern that the conflict was pushing Egypt away from the West. Soviet prime minister Nikita Khrushchev was afraid that Western influence would steal Egypt away from his sphere of influence. Thus, oddly, both the East and West shared the opinion that French, British, and Israeli forces needed to withdraw. The USSR leveraged the Suez crisis to attempt to

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Playing the Game:

The East and West in '56 (Continued)

strengthen its influence on Egypt and fracture the Western bloc, while in a way the US used it to put Britain, France, and Israel in their place. They were still allies, close allies, but America was in power.



After the Suez crisis, it was clearer that the Cold War was being fought between puppeteers US and the USSR. All other players were merely marionettes. The puppets would do the fighting, the “hot” action, but the puppeteers had the power to control them from afar and fight a “cold” war.

The Sèvres Protocol (1956)

The pact between Britain, France, and Israel that was signed on October 29th, 1956, was at the time completely secret. All 3 parties wanted an attack on Egypt, but Britain and France were rightfully cautious about being seen as aggressors. So, they came up with a plan. Israeli would invade Egypt, and then Britain and France would pass them a fake ceasefire ultimatum with terms they knew Egypt couldn't accept. Following Israel's acceptance and Egypt's denial of the ultimatum, British and French forces moved into Egypt on November 6th, posing as “peacekeepers”. However, it soon became clear that the 3 attacking nations were all working together. In the end, Israel did gain access to the Straits of Tiran, which was very helpful for them, but Nasser was still in power, and they knew that meant there would be future

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The Sèvres Protocol (1956) (Continued)

conflicts.

Israel, being a very young nation, had extra incentives to participate in the Sèvres Protocol. They could strengthen their relationship with both Britain and France, while gaining territorial assets. Unfortunately for them, the main international-relations outcome of the protocol was the fostering of untrustworthiness from America.

Suez Crisis - Summary

Who? Egypt vs. Israel, Britain, and France. US and USSR acted as puppeteers.

What? Tripartite Aggressors invaded Egypt and claimed the area around Suez, before being forced to fall back under pressure from the US and USSR.

When? 29 October – 7 November 1956.

Where? Egypt, specifically the Suez and Sinai regions.

Why? A whole host of reasons, but fundamentally the Suez Canal was very important, and multiple stakeholders all felt it belonged to them.

Political Leaders

US: Dwight Eisenhower

USSR: Nikita Khrushchev

Britain: Anthony Eden

France: Guy Mollet

Israel: David Ben-Gurion

Egypt: Gamal Nasser

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-THE SIX DAY WAR TOOK PLACE IN 1967, FROM JUNE 5TH – 10TH . THE WAR INVOLVED ISRAEL WHO DEFEATED EGYPT, JORDAN, AND SYRIA. THE WAR WAS FAUT OVER GAZA STRIP, SINAI PENINSULA, WEST BANK, EAST JERUSALEM, AND THE GOLAN HEIGHTS.

IN 1967, THE SUZE CANAL WAS A MAJOR TRADING ROUTE. WHOEVER HELD CONTROL OVER THE CANAL HELD POWER OVER TRADING IN THE WHOLE AREA. THE SUZE WOULD ALLOW TRADING BETWEEN ASIA AND THE MEDITERRANEAN, THE POWER AND ECONOMIC GROWTH WOULD BE SUBSTANTIAL FOR ANY COUNTRY HOLDING CONTROL OVER THE CANAL.

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The Aswan dam was an important piece of land because it has historically been entangled with the cold war. In 1956 the funding from the U.S.A and Great Britain had been removed, after Nasser established closer ties with the Soviet bloc. The Aswan dam itself was not important to the U.S.A or Britain but it gave both of those governments financial power.



The goals of Egypt in 1967 was to modernize and become a nationalistic society. Egypt wanted to modernize their education by making it free up to university level. Gamal Abdel Nasser wanted to shift the economy in Egypt to a “war economy”.



Who got what at the end of the six-day war, Israel controlled the eastern bank, which included the Suez Canal, Sinai Peninsula up to the waterway, this allowed Israel to gain water, rezone and security. Israel gained security from the territory depth after the six-day war.

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War of Attrition (1967-1970)

The War of Attrition was a military conflict mainly fought between Egypt and Israel along the Suez Canal after the Six-Day War of 1967. Instead of large invasions, the war was fought through constant artillery battles, air strikes, and small military raids. Both sides tried to weaken each other over time rather than win quickly.

The war happened because the Six-Day War changed control of land but did not solve the political conflict. Israel captured the Sinai Peninsula from Egypt, which gave Israel stronger military protection. However, Egypt saw losing Sinai as humiliating and dangerous. Egypt needed to show it was still capable of resisting Israel and wanted to eventually regain the territory.

Israel refused to give the land back without peace agreements because Sinai protected Israel from invasion. This created a situation where Egypt needed to challenge Israeli control, but neither side wanted a full-scale war. Attrition became the best option.

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Israel's Goals

From Israel's perspective, the War of Attrition happened because Israel wanted to keep control of the Sinai Peninsula after winning it in the Six-Day War. Sinai gave Israel more distance from their enemy's armies and made surprise attacks more difficult, which helped Israel feel safer. Israel also believed that if it gave the land back too easily, other countries might see that as a sign of weakness and attack again. Because of this, Israel responded strongly to Egyptian attacks with air strikes and military retaliation. Israeli leaders hoped that by showing strength, Egypt would eventually stop fighting and accept the situation.

Egypt's Goals

From Egypt's perspective, the War of Attrition happened because Egypt could not accept losing the Sinai Peninsula after the Six-Day War. Losing Sinai was embarrassing, weakened Egypt's military reputation, and made the country feel less safe. Egypt also was not strong enough to start another large war yet, so instead it used smaller, constant attacks to pressure Israel while rebuilding its army. Egyptian leaders also wanted to prove to their people and other Arab countries that Egypt was still fighting and had not given up, and they hoped that ongoing pressure might eventually force Israel to negotiate or leave Sinai.

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1968: The Fighting Starts

In 1968, the fighting began along the Suez Canal. Egypt started with artillery attacks across the canal. Israel responded by strengthening its defenses along the canal. These actions were ordered by Gamal Abdel Nasser, who chose small attacks because Egypt was not strong enough for a full invasion. Instead of large battles, the conflict became steady and ongoing, with both sides preparing for long-term fighting.

1969: The War Escalates

When Egypt officially declared the War of Attrition, fighting along the Suez Canal became more intense. Heavy artillery battles became constant, and Israel responded by launching air strikes inside Egypt. Egypt's Chief of Staff, Abdel Moneim Riad, helped lead aggressive attacks and pushed for more pressure on Israeli forces. On Israel's side, Defense Minister Moshe Dayan expanded the use of air strikes, while Prime Minister Golda Meir supported strong military retaliation and refused to consider giving Sinai back. The fighting became daily and more serious, with Israel gaining an early advantage through air power, while Egypt continued the war to rebuild its military and challenge Israeli control.

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1969 - 1970: Cold War Involvement

As the war continued, the Soviet Union increased their military support of Egypt. Soviet leader Leonid Brezhnev supported Egypt by sending weapons and military advisors to strengthen Soviet influence and rebuild Egypt's military strength. On Israel's side, General Ariel Sharon led aggressive counterattacks near Sinai. As Egypt improved its defenses, Israel's air advantage became weaker, and the conflict became more dangerous because Cold War powers were now more directly involved.

1970: Leadership and Growing Risks

As the war continued, fighting along the canal remained constant, and Egypt's air defense systems became stronger, making Israeli air attacks more dangerous. At the same time, the risk of a larger international conflict increased because of growing Cold War involvement. After Gamal Abdel Nasser died, Anwar Sadat became Egypt's leader and continued rebuilding the Egyptian military. In Israel, Prime Minister Golda Meir and Israeli military leaders continued defending Sinai but began recognizing that air combat was becoming more risky and less predictable. Neither side was able to achieve a clear victory, and the war became increasingly costly and difficult to control.

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August 1970: The War Ends

The war ended when a ceasefire agreement stopped the fighting, even though borders stayed the same. The ceasefire was pushed mainly by the United States, with President Richard Nixon encouraging diplomacy to prevent the conflict from escalating into a direct Cold War confrontation. Soviet leader Leonid Brezhnev also supported the ceasefire to avoid direct conflict with the United States. Although the fighting stopped, the underlying conflict between Egypt and Israel was not resolved.

Afterwards

After the war ended, both countries changed their military strategies and prepared for future conflict rather than reaching peace. Egypt gained important combat experience, rebuilt confidence in its army, and improved coordination, especially with their air defense systems, which later helped Egypt plan another attempt to retake Sinai. Israel kept control of Sinai and maintained its security advantage, but the war showed that Israeli air power was not unbeatable and forced Israel to rethink parts of its defense strategy. Tension between Egypt and Israel remained high, and the lessons and military preparations from this conflict directly contributed to the start of the 1973 Yom Kippur War.

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Nasser Dies

When Gamal Abdel Nasser died in 1970, Egypt lost their leader who had guided the country through the Six-Day War and the War of Attrition. Egypt was still dealing with losing the Sinai Peninsula and many people felt embarrassed and frustrated after repeated military defeats. Anwar Sadat replaced Nasser and slowly began changing Egypt's strategy. Instead of continuing long, exhausting fighting, Sadat believed Egypt needed one strong and surprising military success to force Israel into negotiations. He started rebuilding Egypt's army with help from the Soviet Union and began planning future military action.

Preparing for War

During this period, Egypt rebuilt its military and trained soldiers specifically to cross the Suez Canal and break Israeli defenses. Sadat also formed an alliance with Syria, led by Hafez al-Assad, so they could attack Israel together. By 1973, Egypt and Syria finalized plans to launch a surprise attack during Yom Kippur, when Israeli forces might be less prepared. Israel, led by Prime Minister Golda Meir, received warnings but believed a large attack was unlikely. Tension in the region increased as both sides prepared for war.

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War Begins and Early Fighting

On October 6, Egypt and Syria launched a coordinated surprise attack on Israel. Egyptian forces crossed the Suez Canal and broke through Israeli defensive lines in Sinai, while Syrian forces attacked Israeli troops in the Golan Heights. Israel was caught off guard and suffered losses. However, Israel quickly mobilized its reserve soldiers and began counterattacking. Israeli forces pushed Syrian troops back and regained most of the Golan Heights, while Egypt tried to push deeper into Sinai but suffered heavy losses. During this time, the Soviet Union sent supplies to Egypt and Syria, while the United States supplied Israel, connecting the war to Cold War tensions.

Israeli Counterattack and Ceasefire

Israeli forces launched a major counterattack and crossed the Suez Canal into Egyptian territory, eventually surrounding Egypt's Third Army. Egypt faced the risk of a major defeat, which increased pressure for international intervention. At the same time, Arab oil-producing countries stopped selling oil to nations supporting Israel, causing a global energy crisis. The United Nations pushed for a ceasefire, and both the United States and Soviet Union worked to prevent the war from turning into a larger global conflict. Fighting officially ended on October 25, 1973.

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What did They Want in the YK War?

Egypt wanted a limited war where it could recover the Sinai, create diplomatic tensions, and force a superpower to intervene.

Egypt also wanted to shift from soviet support to American support, which President Anwar Sadat believed was crucial for Egyptian financial recovery

Syria was more aggressive with its ambitions and wanted to reclaim the Golan Heights while restoring Syrian military honour and establishing Syria as the most powerful Arab military.

The Soviet Union wanted to avoid escalating or dominating the Arab space in order to maintain Détente with the USA, but also needed to maintain superpower status by not abandoning its Arab “clients.”

America wanted to prove American military superiority and undermine the Soviet military by supplying Israel. Ensuring Israel’s success would keep a decisive influence in the Arab space, and hopefully entice Arab countries to American support over Soviet support.

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What did They Want in the YK War?



Saudi Arabia wanted to economically pressure Israel to withdraw from Arab land and address Palestinian concerns. Saudi Arabia didn't want to fight, but did finance the Arab League. The end goal was to advance pan-Arab and pan-Islamic visions under Saudi leadership.

Israel wanted to avoid pre-emptive strikes to maintain American support, maintain previous territory gains, specifically the Sinai and Golan Heights, and to assert Israeli military superiority.

Lebanon and Jordan both chose to stay out of the Yom Kippur war because of fears of fragility, loss, and instability.

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Aftermath

After the war, Israel kept most of the territory it controlled but suffered heavy casualties. Egypt gained confidence because it proved it could successfully challenge Israel's military. Sadat later used this confidence to negotiate peace with Israel and move Egypt closer to the United States, which reduced Soviet influence in the region. The war changed alliances in the Middle East and reshaped Cold War power in the region.

The Cold War:

The Yom Kippur War (1973) was not just a regional Middle Eastern war. It was deeply connected to the global rivalry between the Cold War superpowers. The war became a proxy conflict where larger powers competed for influence without fighting each other directly.

The Soviet Union supported Egypt and Syria by providing weapons, military training, funding, and advisors. The USSR wanted influence in the Middle East, access to military bases and trade routes, and to weaken U.S. allies.

United States supported Israel by sending weapons, supplies, and political backing. The U.S. wanted to keep a strong ally in a region important for global oil and trade, while also stopping Soviet expansion.

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The Cold War:

These alliances developed over time. Both superpowers originally recognized Israel in 1948, but the Soviets later built a strong relationship with Egypt in the 1950s. The U.S. became Israel's main supporter after the Six-Day War (1967), when Israel defeated several Soviet-backed countries.

During the war, Egypt and Syria attacked Israel to regain land lost in 1967 and restore national pride. The conflict became dangerous globally when the U.S. and USSR rushed supplies to their allies and even raised nuclear alert levels, showing how close the Cold War came to direct confrontation.

After the war, Egypt began moving closer to the United States and eventually negotiated peace with Israel. This shift weakened Soviet influence and gave the U.S. more power in the Middle East.

